Sailing into History

WHAT MAKES THEM SHEROES

Roopa and Dilna are the first women officers in Indian Navy history to receive the Shaurya Chakra after completing the first two-person circumnavigation of the globe by Indian women in 2025

With both their fathers serving in the armed forces—Lieutenant Commander Dilna K.'s in the Indian Army and Lieutenant Commander Roopa A.'s in the Indian Air Force—fearlessness was part of their upbringing. Dilna, from Kozhikode, Kerala, joined the Indian Navy in 2014 as a Logistics Officer after becoming a national-level rifle shooter through the National Cadet Corps. Sailing entered her life later, when she volunteered for the Navy's sailing programme while posted in Visakhapatnam. Roopa, born in Puducherry, studied aeronautical engineering at Anna University, Chennai, worked at the National Aerospace Laboratories in Bengaluru, and joined the Navy in 2017 as an Armament Officer, gradually progressing from dinghy-sailing to competitive and ocean sailing.

Their paths converged in 2021 at the Indian Navy's Ocean Sailing Node, INS *Mandovi*, Goa. In 2023, they were among 17 officers selected for the Sagar Parikrama programme, designed to prepare naval officers for demanding long-distance and circumnavigation expeditions. Intensive training followed, covering seamanship, navigation, meteorology, survival, emergency response, engineering and medical care at sea. Before their final selection for Navika Sagar Parikrama II—the Indian Navy's second all-women global sailing expedition—the duo completed demanding voyages to Rio de Janeiro via Cape Town, to Port Louis in Mauritius, and a double-handed (two-person) passage to Port Blair and back, accumulating more than 38,000 nautical miles of sailing experience.

Finally, they set sail from Goa aboard the 56-foot ocean-going sailing vessel INSV *Tarini* on October 2, 2024, and returned on May 29, 2025, after 238 days at sea and more than 25,600 nautical miles across the Indian, Pacific, Atlantic and Southern Oceans—the first Indian women to complete a double-handed circumnavigation of the globe. They are also the first Indians to reach Point Nemo—the most remote point in the world's oceans, located in the South Pacific—by sailboat. This year, they were awarded the Shaurya Chakra for their feat, becoming the first women officers in Indian Navy history to receive the nation's third-highest peacetime gallantry award—a milestone that is already inspiring young girls to dream bigger. ■

— Pradip R. Sagar

LT CDR ROOPA A., 33
Indian Naval Academy, Ezhimala, Kerala

LT CDR DILNA K., 33
Western Naval Command

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"Unconventional dreams are a calling. They give your life meaning and take you towards a version of yourself you may not yet know exists"

—Lt Cdr Roopa A.

"You cannot think about the entire journey at once; you have to focus on what lies immediately ahead. That mindset has stayed with me beyond sailing"

—Lt Cdr Dilna K.



(L-R) Lt Cdr Roopa A. and Lt Cdr Dilna K. on board INSV *Tarini*